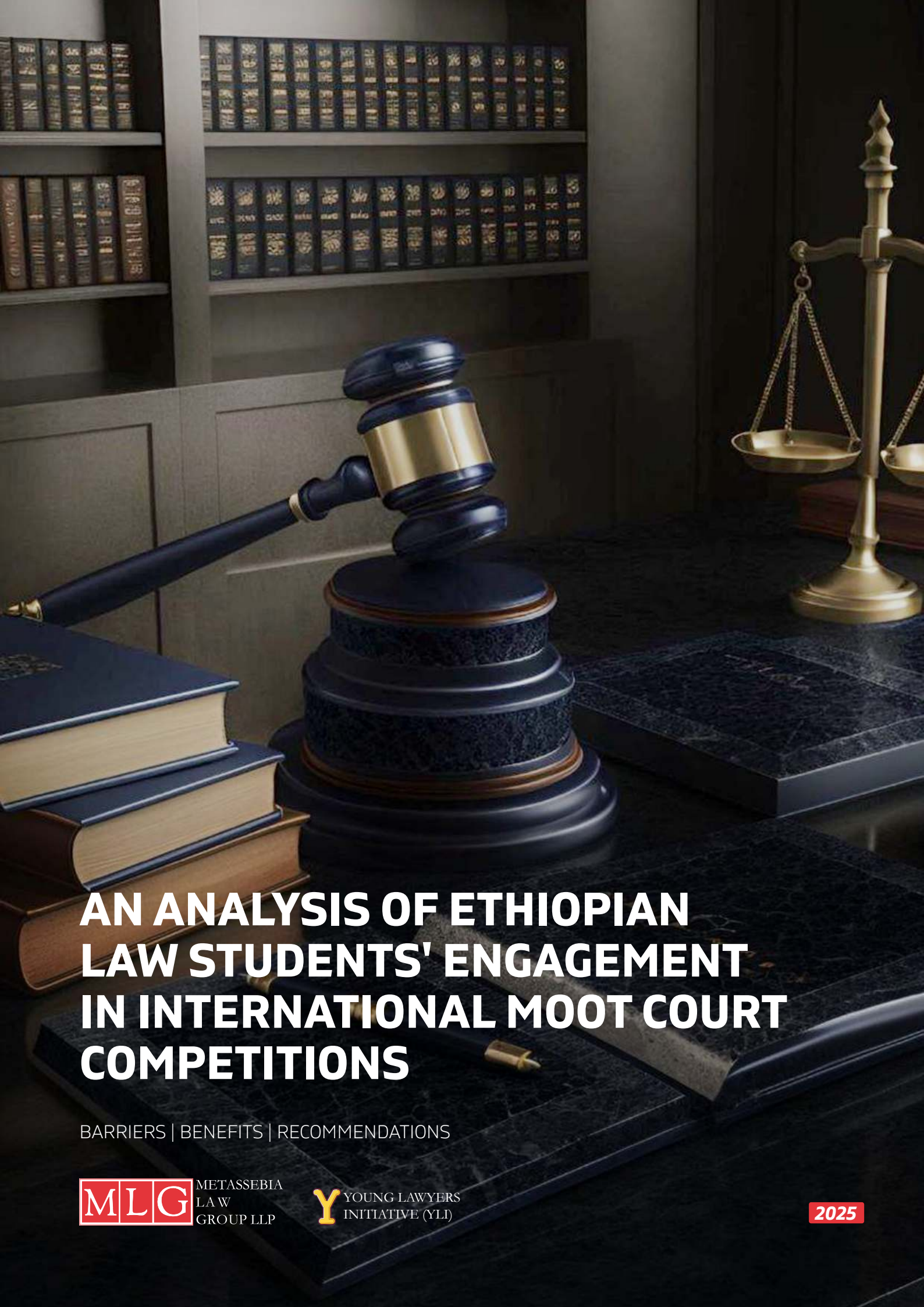




AN ANALYSIS OF ETHIOPIAN LAW STUDENTS' ENGAGEMENT IN INTERNATIONAL MOOT COURT COMPETITIONS

BARRIERS | BENEFITS | RECOMMENDATIONS

PREFACE



METASSEBIA HAILU ZELEKE

Managing Partner, MLG
Founder & Patron of the Young Lawyers
Initiative (YLI)

www.metassebia.com

Welcome to the latest edition of a research magazine, showcasing the exceptional achievements of the Young Lawyers Initiative (YLI) at Metassebia Law Group LLP (MLG). As one of Ethiopia's premier law firms, MLG is committed to shaping the future of our legal profession through innovative initiatives that empower young legal minds.

The YLI stands as a beacon of opportunity, designed to equip law students, recent graduates, and junior practitioners with vital practical skills and invaluable networking experiences.

Under the leadership of our law firm, this initiative has fostered a vibrant community of emerging legal professionals who are poised to make a significant impact in their careers. In a bold move to advance legal scholarship, MLG launched an in-depth research project focused on moot court competitions, engaging our YLI board members and senior fellows in a process designed to enhance their research capabilities. This comprehensive effort included sequenced webinars and collaborative platforms for experience sharing, ensuring a rich understanding of the subject matter. The culmination of this endeavor is the research paper titled "An Analysis of Ethiopian Law Students' Engagement in International Moot Court Competitions: Barriers, Benefits, and Recommendations," which reflects the rigorous methodology employed and incorporates interviews and firsthand insights.

As the founder and mentor of this initiative, I extend my sincere congratulations to all the researchers who navigated the YLI empowerment process with diligence and dedication. These remarkable individuals are invaluable assets to both the local and international legal communities, as well as to academia. I am confident that their contributions will significantly enrich our country's legal landscape. At MLG, we take immense pride in their accomplishments, and we look forward to even greater successes as YLI continues to cultivate high-caliber legal talent. Enjoy your reading!



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Yishak is a 5th year law student at Addis Ababa University and an Executive Board Member of the Young Lawyers Initiative (YLI) under Metassebia Law Group. Deeply committed to both legal scholarship and practical impact, Yishak combines his academic focus with an openness to explore multiple disciplines, from data analytics to writing and research, to broaden his understanding of how different fields intersect with law and society.

and has shared insights through presenting in webinars. His adaptability and curiosity drive him to engage with diverse perspectives and projects, always seeking to uncover how law can better serve people and promote justice.

Outside his formal studies, Yishak is known for his approachable nature and his ability to connect with people from all walks of life, which he believes is essential to legal practice. Looking forward, he aspires to pursue advanced studies abroad and contribute to Ethiopia's evolving legal and educational landscape.

As part of YLI, Yishak has contributed extensively to advancing conversations within Ethiopia's legal community. He has authored multiple articles, published both in Insight magazine and on other platforms, covering topics ranging from voluntarism to mental health in the legal profession. Alongside his editorial work, he has co-led research initiatives, including this study on the challenges and benefits of mootng in Ethiopia,

Nigus, currently in his final year of law school, is a senior principal of MLG's Young Lawyers Initiative (YLI), which he has actively engaged with since its inception. He has contributed to Insight online magazine, organized international webinars, and, in his role as Editor-in-Chief of the Justice Club's bi-weekly legal bulletin, led the organization of the first cross-campus essay competition involving five partner law schools of YLI. He has also served on the editorial committee of the Addis Ababa University Students' Law Review for the past three years and will serve as its Editor-in-Chief for the 2025/26 edition.

A dedicated moot court enthusiast, Nigus has represented his law school in competitions across Nigeria, Australia, Kenya, and Austria, gaining extensive experience and fluency in mootng. Aspiring to become a corporate lawyer with a strong focus on Alternative Dispute Resolution (ADR), particularly arbitration, he holds memberships in organizations such as Young ICCA, Young AFSA, and MAA.

Through his work with YLI, he has helped create a platform where young lawyers are empowered and given opportunities to grow. For this research, he contributed as a writer and conducted in-depth analysis on the current state of mootng in Ethiopia, grounded in both his academic inquiry and personal experience.



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Danat is currently a fifth-year law student at Addis Ababa University, part of the 2025/26 graduating class. In her time at university, she has been deeply engaged in a range of extracurricular initiatives, reflecting both her commitment to legal education and community development. She has served as the Vice President of the Justice Club, where she contributed to legal literacy and advocacy projects, and was also part of the Editorial Board of the AAU Student Law Review, where she supports student scholarship and legal writing excellence. She is a dedicated member of the Rotaract Club of Solyana, currently holding the position of Secretary, taking part in service-oriented projects that blend leadership, fellowship, and community impact. Beyond campus, Danat has played an active role in the Young Lawyers Initiative (YLI), first as a fellow, and now as a Senior Principal, overseeing partnership affairs within the initiative's efforts. Her academic and extracurricular journey reflects her dual interests in children's rights,

Hailemichael is a final-year law student at Addis Ababa University and a board member of the Young Lawyers Initiative (YLI), where he actively contributes to Insight online magazine and has played a key role in organizing national and international webinars aimed at empowering young legal professionals.

He is also serving as the President of the Justice Club, one of the university's most active student-led legal platforms, where he leads initiatives focused on publishing regular legal updates and engaging law students in legal discourse and advocacy. Hailemichael has interned at several high-profile law firms,

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Currently, he is representing Addis Ababa University as a member of the 33rd Willem C. Vis International Commercial Arbitration Moot team, where he focuses on procedural issues and international dispute resolution.

Beyond law, Hailemichael is passionate about leadership and personal development. He is a Kectil Fellow and the first graduate of Ethiopia's pioneering Entrepreneurial Leadership Program, designed to cultivate innovative and socially responsible young leaders across various disciplines.

where she aims to be an impactful advocate, and the evolving field of corporate and business law, which she is now exploring with growing enthusiasm.

Her legal advocacy skills were first tested in the Philip C. Jessup International Law Moot Court Competition, where she earned recognition as First Runner-Up for Best Oralist in the Ethiopian National Rounds. She now continues her moot court journey as a member of the 33rd Willem C. Vis International Commercial Arbitration Moot team, which will represent AAU in the 2026 rounds. Danat is passionate about the intersection of law, youth empowerment, and justice. She hopes to build a career that combines strong legal advocacy with meaningful social impact, particularly in advancing the rights and welfare of children.



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Roza interned at Mehreteab and Getu Advocates LLP and Mesfin Tafesse and Associated, where she supported corporate advisory services. She has also worked with a startup, drafting contracts and policies. As a project lead in the Justice Club and editorial board member of the AAU Student Law Review, she helped shape mentorship programs.

Roza Woldemichael Wana is a gold medalist law graduate from Addis Ababa University, where she graduated top of her class. Her academic and practical interests span international humanitarian law, technology law, and arbitration. She has represented AAU in several prestigious international moot court competitions, including the Willem C. Vis International Commercial Arbitration Moot, the Alfred Deakin International Commercial Arbitration Moot, and the Nuremberg Moot Court.

Roza is part of the Africa in the Moot initiative, as part of the Media & Communications Committees, and is also active in the AAU International Humanitarian Law Clinic, where she combines legal research with creative advocacy through graphic and video production. Passionate about the intersection of law and innovation, she is especially drawn to technology law and the role it plays in advancing justice and development. Roza is currently part of the EMEA Google Legal Summer internship program hosted at Aman & Partners LLP.



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LIST OF ACRONYMS

Acronym	Full Form
YLI	Young Lawyers Initiative
Vis Moot	Willem C. Vis International Commercial Arbitration Moot
Jessup	Philip C. Jessup International Law Moot Court Competition
AHRC Moot	African Human Rights Moot Court Competition
CISG	United Nations Convention on Contracts for the International Sale of Goods
NGO	Non-Governmental Organization

ABSTRACT

This study investigates the level of engagement of Ethiopian undergraduate law students in international moot court competitions, with a particular focus on the Willem C. Vis International Commercial Arbitration Moot. Drawing on survey responses from students across multiple Ethiopian universities, the research reveals a growing interest in moot court participation despite significant barriers, including financial constraints, limited access to legal training, and inadequate institutional support. Although exposure remains limited, students widely acknowledge the transformative value of mooting for developing legal research, writing, and advocacy skills, as well as for enhancing global career prospects.

The findings highlight an urgent need for targeted reforms in awareness-raising, coaching, funding, and institutional recognition. Ultimately, the study advocates for a systemic shift to integrate moot courts as a fundamental component of experiential legal education in Ethiopia.

Keywords:

Moot Court Competitions, Legal Education, Ethiopian Law Students, Legal Skills Development



CHAPTER ONE

INTRODUCTION

1.1. Background of the study

Moot court competitions serve as a cornerstone of practical legal education worldwide, offering students an invaluable platform to hone their legal research, writing, and oral advocacy skills in a simulated courtroom environment. These competitions bridge the gap between theoretical knowledge acquired in classrooms and the practical application of law, preparing future legal professionals for the complexities of real-world litigation and arbitration. In Ethiopia, as the legal landscape continues to evolve, the significance of such experiential learning opportunities for law students cannot be overstated.

This paper analyses survey data from law students across various Ethiopian universities to provide an understanding of the existing moot court ecosystem and to propose concrete recommendations for its enhancement, particularly with a view to increasing Ethiopian students' engagement with prestigious international competitions like the Vis Moot.

Understanding the experiences of students and identifying the gaps in current support structures is crucial for designing targeted interventions that can unlock their full potential.

1.2. Statement of the Problem

While moot court competitions are internationally recognized as essential tools for developing legal skills, many Ethiopian undergraduate law students remain underexposed to these platforms, particularly international moots such as the Willem C. Vis Moot. This limited exposure not only curtails opportunities for students to enhance their legal research, writing, and

advocacy skills but also places them at a disadvantage in global academic and professional arenas. Despite a growing interest among students, multiple barriers, ranging from lack of awareness and training to financial and institutional constraints, continue to hinder meaningful participation. Without a clear understanding of the scale and root causes of this issue, sustainable solutions remain elusive.

1.3. Research Questions

1. To what extent are undergraduate law students in Ethiopia exposed to international moot court competitions?
2. What are the major gaps and barriers that hinder their exposure and participation?
3. What strategies and recommendations can be proposed to overcome these barriers and foster greater engagement?

1.4. Objectives of the Study

1.4.1. General Objective

To assess the level of exposure to international moot court competitions among Ethiopian undergraduate law students and propose recommendations for addressing existing challenges.

1.4.2. Specific Objectives

- To identify the extent of exposure that undergraduate law students in Ethiopia have to international moot court competitions.
- To examine the barriers that hinder their exposure to and participation in such competitions.
- To propose recommendations to overcome these barriers and enhance moot court engagement.

1.5. Significance of the Study

This study offers crucial insights for academic institutions, legal educators, and policymakers in Ethiopia. By identifying the gaps in moot court engagement, the research aims to support reforms that enhance experiential legal education and global competitiveness among Ethiopian law students. Furthermore, the findings can guide donors, NGOs, and legal associations in developing targeted interventions, sponsorship programs, and capacity-building efforts. The study also contributes to the broader discourse on equity in legal education and professional development.

1.6. Delimitations (Scope) of the Study

The research focuses solely on undergraduate law students in Ethiopia, with particular emphasis on their awareness of, access to, and participation in international moot court competitions. It primarily considers competitions such as the Vis Moot, Jessup, and African Human Rights Moot Court. The geographical scope covers a selection of public and private universities across the country, but does not extend to postgraduate students or non-law disciplines.

1.6.1. Limitations of the Study

This study is subject to several limitations. First, the sample size was relatively small and may not be fully representative of all undergraduate law students across Ethiopia. The findings primarily reflect the perspectives of students who responded to the survey, which may introduce response bias. Additionally, due to time and logistical constraints, the research did not include

in-depth institutional case studies or perspectives from university administrators and faculty, which could have enriched the analysis. The reliance on self-reported data may also affect the accuracy and objectivity of some responses. Finally, the absence of centralized or publicly available data on moot court participation in Ethiopian universities limited the scope of comparative analysis across institutions.

1.7. Research Methodology

1.7.1. Research Approach and Design

This study employed a descriptive research design to explore the extent of exposure undergraduate law students in Ethiopia have to international moot court competitions. The research utilized a mixed-methods approach, combining both quantitative and qualitative data derived from a single structured questionnaire. The approach allowed for the identification of trends, challenges, and student-generated recommendations based on their experiences and perceptions.

1.7.2. Sources of Data

The primary source of data was a structured questionnaire completed by undergraduate law students from various universities in Ethiopia. No secondary sources or external datasets were used in the analysis.

1.7.3. Data Collection Method

Data were collected through the distribution of an online questionnaire. The instrument consisted of both closed-ended questions designed to gather quantifiable information and open-ended questions intended to capture narrative insights from the respondents. Participation in the study was voluntary and anonymous.

1.7.4. Method of Analysis and Presentation

Quantitative data were analyzed using descriptive statistical methods to determine frequencies and proportions of responses. Qualitative responses were reviewed and categorized thematically to identify recurring ideas, challenges, and proposed solutions. The results are presented in a narrative format, supported by statistical summaries and representative statements from respondents.

1.8. Literature Review

1.8.1. Introduction to Moot Court as a Pedagogical Tool

Definition and Purpose

A moot court is a simulated court or arbitration proceeding where law students act as advocates for fictional parties, allowing them to practice negotiating and presenting cases as if in a real courtroom. Its educational value lies in bridging the gap between legal theory and practice by developing crucial skills such as legal research, writing, oral advocacy, teamwork, and persuasive speaking. Through moot court competitions, students enhance their legal knowledge,

European Law Students' Association. (2019). Moot Court Competitions Handbook: ELSA Moot Court Competitions 2019|2020 (p. 5). ELSA.

European Law Students' Association. (2019). Moot Court Competitions Handbook: ELSA Moot Court Competitions 2019|2020 (p. 5). ELSA.

gain confidence, improve their rhetorical abilities, and prepare for the practical demands expected by future employers, skills that are often not fully covered in traditional university courses.

Theoretical Framework

Moot court aligns closely with Kolb's Experiential Learning Theory (ELT), which postulates that meaningful learning occurs through a cyclical process involving concrete experience, reflective observation, abstract conceptualization, and active experimentation. Moot court experiences reflect this model: students begin with concrete experience through simulated cases, reflect on outcomes and strategies, formulate abstract arguments grounded in law, and test their reasoning through repetitive rounds of advocacy. By engaging students in all four phases of Kolb's learning cycle, moot courts offer a comprehensive framework for legal skill development.

Kolb further outlines distinct learning styles, Diverging, Assimilating, Converging, and Accommodating. That reflects how individuals approach learning tasks. Moot court participation accommodates various styles : Divergers benefit from group deliberation and feedback, Assimilators engage deeply in legal theory, Convergers apply rules to practical cases, and Accommodators thrive in action-oriented simulations. By embracing these varied learning preferences, moot court activities offer an inclusive and dynamic educational experience that fosters both intellectual and professional growth.

Moot court practice exemplifies the core principles of constructivist learning, as described by Olmedo Torre et al. (2021), who explain that learning is an active, subjective process where individuals construct knowledge through personal experience and reflection.¹ In moot courts, law students do not merely absorb legal rules but actively engage in constructing arguments,

European Law Students' Association. (2019). Moot Court Competitions Handbook: ELSA Moot Court Competitions 2019|2020 (p. 5). ELSA.

Kolb, D. A., Boyatzis, R. E., & Mainemelis, C. (1999). *Experiential learning theory: Previous research and new directions* (p. 5). Department of Organizational Behavior, Case Western Reserve University.

interpreting facts, and applying doctrines in simulated courtroom settings. This aligns with the constructivist emphasis on learners building their own understanding by connecting new experiences to prior knowledge and by participating in social contexts where meaning is negotiated collectively.

Moreover, moot courts embody the constructivist notion that effective learning environments should promote problem-solving, collaboration, and contextual learning.³ As Olmedo Torre et al. note, constructivist environments encourage learners to participate in meaningful tasks that mirror real-life situations, facilitating deeper understanding and skill acquisition.⁴ Through role-play and legal argumentation, moot court participants develop not only legal knowledge but also critical thinking, communication skills, and professional identity all key outcomes in a constructivist educational model.

1.8.2. Moot Court Practice in Ethiopia

Legal Education Landscape

In Ethiopia, the Higher Education Proclamation No. 351/2003 establishes that universities and their faculties serve three main functions: delivering quality education, conducting research, and engaging in community service. In response to the challenge of aligning theoretical legal training with practical skills and community engagement, the revised national LL.B. curriculum now integrates numerous skill-focused courses and Clinical Legal Education (CLE) programs.

Although CLE is modeled after medical training where students learn through hands-on practice, in law it involves students acquiring legal skills by working under supervision, often in contexts promoting social justice. CLE may take the form of simulation clinics such as moot courts which offer experiential learning by letting students assume the roles of lawyers in hypothetical cases, thus providing an accessible and structured way to develop lawyering skills despite not replicating real-life complexities fully.

Higher Education Proclamation, 2003, Art. 6(1), (2), (4), (5)

Tadesse, M. (2009). Clinical legal education in Ethiopia: Challenges and their possible way out. Addis Ababa University.

Duncan, 2005; Clinical Legal Education Association, 2007.

The new Ethiopian LL.B. curriculum spans five years and comprises 83 courses totaling at least 154 credit hours of coursework, alongside 20 credit hours devoted to externship and exit exams. Of these, 37 are core courses mandatory for all law schools, while 40 are electives, with clinical courses included in the elective list, allowing faculties to tailor offerings based on community needs. Although making CLE optional avoids excessive costs and redundancy in teaching similar skills across multiple clinics, some educators advocate introducing clinical courses earlier in the fourth rather than solely the fifth year to provide students more extensive practical exposure, especially considering smaller class sizes of 20-30 students are necessary for effective. Moreover, proposals have been made to expand clinical course credit hours from three to six to accommodate the extensive practical work required, while clear placement criteria, based on entrance exams and academic performance, aim to ensure fairness in allocating students to limited clinical spots.

Overall, while the curriculum harmonization mandated under seeks to standardize legal education across institutions, ongoing adjustments reflect a continued effort to balance theoretical instruction with practical training in Ethiopia's LL.B. programs.

Research Gaps

Despite the increasing popularity of moot court competitions in Ethiopia, significant research gaps remain. There is a lack of comprehensive data documenting the extent of student participation, the level of institutional support provided by law schools, and the outcomes of such engagements. Moreover, minimal scholarly work exists exploring students' experiences in moot courts or examining the systemic challenges they face, such as resource constraints, training quality, and access to mentorship. This gap limits stakeholders' ability to design targeted interventions to strengthen moot court practice as a vital component of legal education and professional development in the country.

1.8.3. Challenges in Moot Court Implementation (Ethiopian Focus)

Firstly, a moot court needs suitable premises, including a courtroom-style hall for hearings, rooms for participants to prepare and confer, and spaces that ensure security and confidentiality

Addis Ababa University, School of Law. (2022). Revised Bachelor of Laws curriculum. Addis Ababa University.

Tadesse, M. (2009). Clinical legal education in Ethiopia: Challenges and their possible way out. Addis Ababa University.

during proceedings. There also needs to be an area where students can be debriefed, discuss cases, and receive important notices. Facilities for offering basic hospitality to participants and guests (such as tea and coffee) should be available, along with access to toilets. Secondly, the moot court requires essential equipment. At a minimum, this includes a sound system, recording equipment for documenting proceedings, computers, desks, chairs, and robes for students, and filing cabinets for storing case materials, transportation arrangements for participants attending external competitions, a photocopy machine, and various stationery supplies.

As noted by Tadesse Lencho, former Acting Dean of the Faculty of Law at Addis Ababa University, even the country's oldest law faculty at Addis Ababa University is inadequately equipped to establish a legal clinic. According to his report: The Faculty originally began its operations in a building that was not designed for academic purposes.

In the case of newly established universities, the situation is even more challenging. These institutions often lack sufficient reference books, teaching materials, and proper libraries, let alone suitable buildings and equipment necessary to operate legal clinics.

A survey conducted by the Justice and Legal System Research Institute across 23 law schools revealed stark deficiencies: over 16 of these law schools do not have their own separate buildings, more than 14 lack a proper moot court room, over 14 share libraries with other faculties, and more than 10 have no access to internet services.

Ethiopia is home to more than 84 ethnic groups, each with its own distinct language. While this linguistic diversity is a cultural asset, it also presents significant challenges to the effective implementation of moot court programs in the country's law schools.

One key aim of moot court exercises is to train students to draft legal documents, present oral arguments, and engage in simulated court proceedings. However, students often face language barriers that hinder their participation. For example, consider a law student from the Amhara region studying at a College

Tadesse, M. (2009). Clinical legal education in Ethiopia: Challenges and their possible way out. Addis Ababa University.
Tadesse, M. (2009). Clinical legal education in Ethiopia: Challenges and their possible way out. Addis Ababa University.
Justice and Legal System Research Institute, Profile of Ethiopian Law Schools and Their Staff: Results of Baseline Survey (2008).

of Law in Sidama, whose primary language is Amharic and who does not speak the local language. Such a student would struggle to participate effectively in a moot court conducted in the local language, the working language of the courts in Sidama. This language gap prevents the student from preparing court submissions, delivering oral arguments, or responding to judges' questions in the local language. Students who lack proficiency in the language of the region where their law school operates are unable to fully engage in moot court activities tailored to that local legal context.

1.9. Organization of the study

The study is structured into four chapters:

- **Chapter One** outlines the background of the study, the problem statement, research objectives, significance, scope, methodology, and overall organization of the research.

- **Chapter Two** presents a detailed analysis and interpretation of the data collected through the survey aiding in understanding the landscape familiarity and participation of moot courts.
- **Chapter Three** explores the Challenges Faced by Ethiopian Law Students in Moot Court Participation
- **Chapter Four** dives into the Benefits of Moot Court Participation
- **Chapter Five** concludes the study by summarizing key insights and proposing directions for future research.



CHAPTER TWO

UNDERSTANDING THE LANDSCAPE

FAMILIARITY AND PARTICIPATION

Introduction

Understanding the level of familiarity and actual participation among Ethiopian law students in international moot court competitions provides critical context for evaluating broader engagement. This section presents data collected from survey respondents regarding their awareness, exposure, and involvement in competitions such as the Willem C. Vis Moot. The findings highlight both a growing interest in mooting and the existing limitations that shape students' opportunities to participate effectively.

2.1. Familiarity with Moot Court Competitions

The findings indicate that while the concept of "moot court" is generally familiar to Ethiopian law students, a significant gap remains in awareness regarding specific international competitions, particularly the Willem C. Vis International Commercial Arbitration Moot.

2.1.1. General Awareness of Moot Courts

A substantial majority of respondents (15 out of 19) affirmed familiarity with the general concept of moot courts, indicating a foundational understanding of their role in legal education. This suggests that the idea of simulated legal advocacy exercises has been integrated, at least conceptually, into the broader legal curriculum. However, this baseline awareness does not appear to extend to knowledge of particular international moot competitions.

Limited Visibility of the Vis Moot

Among the 14 respondents who addressed the question regarding familiarity with the Vis Moot:

- Only one student (Natan Yisihak) described themselves as "Very Familiar."
- Two others (Kidist Girma and Hasan Ahmedin) had only "Heard of It."
- One respondent (Tilahun Gebretsadik) was "Fairly Familiar."
- A striking majority, nine respondents, indicated they had "Never Heard" of the competition.

This pattern reveals a striking lack of exposure to one of the most prestigious moot competitions in the field of international commercial arbitration. The limited recognition of the Vis Moot may be attributed to several institutional and structural barriers, including limited promotion, lack of alumni networks, and absence of formal preparation frameworks within universities.

Recognition of Other Moot Court Competitions

A similar trend of limited awareness emerges when examining familiarity with other international moot court competitions. For the Philip C. Jessup International Law Moot Court Competition, while two respondents reported being either "Very Familiar" or "Fairly Familiar," the majority had limited or no awareness, seven had "Never Heard" of it and three had only "Heard of It."

The African Human Rights Moot Court Competition demonstrated slightly higher levels of recognition, likely due to its regional focus and historical participation by Ethiopian institutions. Two respondents reported being "Fairly Familiar," and one was "Very Familiar." Nonetheless, seven respondents still had "Never Heard" of the competition, suggesting that even regionally accessible opportunities remain under-publicized.

For more specialized competitions, such as the Jean-Pictet Competition and the FIAE Moot, familiarity was minimal. Most respondents indicated they had “Never Heard” of either, reflecting the niche nature of these moots and their limited penetration into Ethiopian legal academic spaces.

Taken together, these findings underscore a critical gap in the visibility and accessibility of international moot court competitions for Ethiopian law students. While students appear eager to engage with these platforms, as indicated elsewhere in the survey, their participation is hindered by a lack of structured exposure and institutional encouragement. As one respondent aptly observed, the “lack of information and encouragement” remains a key obstacle. Addressing this issue requires deliberate awareness-raising strategies, mentorship programs, and stronger integration of moot court culture within university settings.

2.2 Participation in Moot Court Competitions

The survey results demonstrate a strong and consistent interest in moot court competitions among Ethiopian law students, including among those who have not yet participated. This enthusiasm suggests that moot courts are increasingly viewed not merely as extracurricular activities but as vital platforms for professional growth, skills development, and international exposure.

2.2.1. Prior Participation in Moot Court Competitions

Out of 19 respondents, 10 reported having previously participated in at least one moot court competition, while 9 indicated they had not.

Among those with prior experience, the Philip C. Jessup International Law Moot Court Competition was the most frequently mentioned, with six participants. This was followed by the African Human Rights Moot Court (five respondents), and the Willem C. Vis International Commercial Arbitration Moot, which was mentioned by two students. Additional mentions included participation in national-level competitions and other human rights-related moots, such as one referred to as “Competition on Human Right.”

Although the number of students who have participated in international competitions is relatively small, the presence of Jessup and Vis Moot alumni, however few, suggests an entry point for peer mentorship and institutional memory. These individuals may serve as important catalysts for expanding participation through informal support systems and knowledge sharing.

Desire for Future Participation

Even more striking than past participation is the widespread and enthusiastic interest in future engagement. In response to the question, “If given the opportunity, would you participate in the Vis Moot or support a team going?”, 10 out of 11 respondents answered “Yes, definitely,” with the remaining respondent indicating “To some extent.” Similarly, when asked whether they would be interested in participating in moot court competitions in general, 16 out of 19 respondents affirmed their interest. This indicates that moot courts are seen not only as accessible and desirable, but as aspirational opportunities for self-improvement and professional advancement.

The qualitative responses further reinforce this sentiment. Students cited a range of motivations for wanting to participate, including:

- *"To learn more about the legal community and gain more skills for my future practice."*
- *"For the invaluable learning experience."*
- *"To gain practical knowledge and improve debate skills."*
- *"To get exposure to arbitration and mediation laws."*
- *"Because it would be a transformative experience."*
- *"To create connection with the world."*

These reflections show that students are not only aware of the personal and academic value of moots but also recognize their global and professional dimensions. The desire to engage in arbitration-specific competitions like the Vis Moot further suggests an emerging awareness of specialized legal fields such as international commercial arbitration, even among those with no prior exposure.

The evident enthusiasm, especially for competitions like the Vis Moot, underscores a critical opportunity for capacity-building within Ethiopian law schools. Students are motivated, eager to learn, and recognize the benefits of moot court participation, even in the absence of institutional structures, financial resources, or prior exposure. The fact that interest in future participation exceeds current participation reflects a demand that is not being adequately met, due to what one respondent previously identified as a "lack of information and encouragement." This gap between interest and access calls for strategic intervention by law faculties, student clubs, and legal organizations.

This includes providing accurate information about competitions, creating preparatory workshops, building alumni networks, and ensuring institutional support, such as coaching, funding, and logistical coordination. Given the visibility and career-enhancing potential of international moots, including the Vis Moot, there is a strong case for treating moot court participation not as an extracurricular luxury but as an integral component of legal education.

Understanding the level of familiarity and actual participation among Ethiopian law students in international moot court competitions provides critical context for evaluating broader engagement. This section presents data collected from survey respondents regarding their awareness, exposure, and involvement in competitions such as the Willem C. Vis Moot. The findings highlight both a growing interest in mooting and the existing limitations that shape students' opportunities to participate effectively.



CHAPTER THREE

CHALLENGES FACED BY ETHIOPIAN LAW STUDENTS IN MOOT COURT PARTICIPATION

Introduction

Despite the strong interest and enthusiasm expressed by Ethiopian law students toward international moot court competitions, several structural and practical barriers hinder their meaningful participation. This section presents the key challenges identified through the survey, shedding light on the core institutional, financial, academic, and informational constraints that continue to limit access. Understanding these challenges is crucial for developing targeted interventions that can democratize opportunities and foster a more inclusive and competitive mooting environment.

3.1. Financial and Logistical Barriers

Among the most pressing challenges identified by respondents are the financial and logistical barriers that significantly hinder student participation in moot court competitions, particularly at the international level. These challenges are not only frequent but also deeply structural, limiting the ability of students to engage meaningfully despite their interest and commitment.

3.1.1. Funding Constraintst

Financial limitations emerge as the most commonly cited obstacle, with 10 out of 19 respondents explicitly identifying funding as the most difficult aspect of moot court participation. The costs associated with international competitions are substantial and multifaceted. They include registration fees, airfare, visa expenses, and accommodation, all of which can be prohibitive for students and institutions with limited budgets. As Dawit Asnake Ejigu notes, "cost is a major barrier. Travel, registration, and accommodation are expensive." Similarly, Kidist Nuru emphasizes the need for "financial assistance" and highlights the challenge of "finding sponsorship" as a critical limitation. These responses illustrate a strong consensus that the financial demands of participation are out of reach for many, without dedicated institutional or external funding support.

3.1.2. Inconsistent Logistical Support

In addition to funding, logistical support is a key concern. Some respondents acknowledged that their universities provide a degree of assistance, such as help with travel arrangements, visa processing, and accommodation. However, this support is inconsistent and often inadequate. The administrative complexity of international travel and the time-sensitive nature of visa applications present serious hurdles. When such logistical support is lacking, it becomes nearly impossible for many students to navigate the bureaucratic processes involved, regardless of their qualifications or preparation.

3.1.3. Limited Access to Essential Resources

The lack of institutional access to essential legal research tools further compounds the challenges students face. Moot court competitions demand intensive legal research, often involving foreign jurisdictions and specialized areas of international law. Several respondents underscored the importance of access to legal databases and reference materials. Tilahun Gebretsadik explicitly pointed to "access to legal databases" as a necessary component of institutional support. Without such resources, students are placed at a disadvantage, unable to prepare to the same standard as their peers from better-resourced institutions.

Taken together, these financial and logistical barriers represent a major structural limitation that disproportionately affects students in low-resource academic environments. Addressing them will require not only increased funding and institutional commitment but also the development of partnerships and support systems that can provide students with the tools and opportunities they need to participate fully and competitively.

3.2 Information Gaps and Lack of Awareness

Despite high levels of student interest, a significant barrier to participation in international moot court competitions remains the lack of accessible and timely information. This information gap manifests both in the general unawareness of competitions and in the absence of guidance on how to engage with them.

Many students reported being unaware of the existence of major international moots or the procedures required for participation.

This challenge is especially pronounced among students from universities located outside the capital. For example, Walin Tedese Korsu from Bule Hora University indicated that they had "Never Heard" of any of the listed international moot court competitions, underscoring the depth of this awareness gap.

Respondents described the issue in clear terms. One noted the "lack of information and encouragement," while another emphasized that students often "lack necessary information about the Vis Moot, such as when and how it is conducted and what it focuses on." These comments reflect a broader systemic issue in how information is disseminated across legal institutions.

Suggestions for addressing this gap reveal a desire for more structured and consistent communication mechanisms. Abel Tesfaye Yitayih recommended "making a better information sharing structure" as a solution, indicating that the current methods of circulating moot court opportunities are inadequate. This highlights the need for institutional investment in communication platforms, centralized opportunity boards, or dedicated moot court coordinators within law faculties who can ensure that all students have access to relevant and timely information, regardless of their university's location or resource level.

3.3 Training and Preparation Deficiencies

Participation in moot court competitions, particularly at the international level, requires rigorous preparation that extends beyond classroom learning. However, the survey responses make it clear that many Ethiopian law schools lack the capacity to provide the specialized training needed for effective participation in such events.

One respondent directly cited the "lack of experience and lack of training and coaching" as a major barrier. This is consistent with the broader findings, which show that "better training or coaching" was the most frequently suggested solution, mentioned by 9 out of 19 respondents. Students clearly recognize that success in moot court competitions is not solely based on theoretical knowledge but also depends on practical skills development.

The need for training spans a wide range of competencies. Students expressed particular interest in learning how teams prepare and conduct legal research, how they draft and format memorials, and how they develop and deliver oral arguments. For instance, Kidist Girma listed a detailed set of training needs, including how to research and prepare, how to write memoranda, how to manage time and resources, how to navigate the competition environment, and how to leverage the experience for professional development. This comprehensive reflection illustrates the scope of support students are seeking.

Respondents who had previously participated in moot courts frequently cited "preparing memorials" and "oral advocacy" as the most challenging aspects of their experience. These core components of competition preparation require ongoing guidance, structured feedback, and access to experienced coaches or mentors, resources that are often unavailable to many students.

3.4 Time Management and Academic Pressure

Balancing the intensive demands of moot court participation with ongoing academic obligations presents a considerable challenge for many students.

Moot court competitions require significant time investment for research, drafting memorials, and oral advocacy practice. For students already managing a full academic workload, this additional responsibility often leads to stress and scheduling conflicts.

Time constraints were explicitly identified by 9 out of 19 respondents as one of the most difficult aspects of participating in moot court activities. The preparation required for international competitions in particular is time-consuming, often overlapping with exam periods or major academic deadlines. As Walin Tedese Korsä noted, students may be "busy by the other matter" during moot preparation or proposal development. The remark reflects the broader difficulty of aligning moot schedules with academic calendars, particularly when students must also manage personal responsibilities or limited access to internet or resources. These competing demands hinder consistent preparation and participation, often placing dedicated students at a disadvantage.

3.5 Institutional Support Gaps

Institutional support for moot court programs varies widely across universities and is frequently described as inadequate. While some students benefit from active guidance and logistical assistance, many report receiving little or no support, thereby limiting their ability to participate fully or competitively.

Student perceptions of their universities' support reveal significant disparities. Out of 16 respondents who rated the level of institutional support, 3 rated it as "Excellent", 4 as "Good", 3 as "Fair", and 5 as "Poor". One respondent reported receiving "No support at all." This distribution indicates inconsistency in university-level commitment to moot court participation and signals the need for more standardized institutional practices.

Beyond academic support, administrative facilitation was also identified as a key area of concern. Hasan Ahmedin explicitly called for greater administrative assistance, implying that bureaucratic hurdles, such as slow internal approvals or unclear processes, can further hinder participation. Collectively, these issues underscore the need for a more robust and structured framework for institutional support.

3.6 Qualitative Differences Between Local and International Moots

Respondents clearly articulated the qualitative distinctions between local or national moot court competitions and their international counterparts. Their reflections centered on the expanded scale, complexity, and exposure offered by international moots, particularly the Vis Moot.

Several students emphasized the broader thematic scope and reach of international moots. Walin Tedese Korsu noted that while local moot courts tend to focus on domestic legal issues, international moots like the Vis Moot address a wide range of cross-border legal matters. He pointed out that international moots bring together diverse participants and cover a wider field of law, including areas that are not typically addressed in national competitions.

Dawit Asnake Ejigu provided a detailed comparison, noting that the Vis Moot is not only broader in scale but also deeper in experience. He observed that participants are required to engage with real international legal frameworks, particularly the United Nations Convention on Contracts for the International Sale of Goods (CISG) and international commercial arbitration.

Another major distinction highlighted by respondents is the level of professional exposure and networking afforded by international competitions. The opportunity to interact with law students, academics, and practitioners from around the world was described as a uniquely valuable experience. Dawit Asnake Ejigu elaborated on the atmosphere of the Vis Moot, where participants not only compete but also collaborate in pre-moot events and exchange ideas with peers and experts from every continent. He described the sense of community and international engagement as unlike anything found in local or national moots.

The survey responses clearly illustrate that Ethiopian law students are not short on motivation but are significantly constrained by a lack of resources, limited institutional support, and insufficient exposure to moot court opportunities. Financial burdens, inadequate training, poor access to legal research tools, and logistical hurdles remain persistent obstacles. Without intentional and coordinated efforts to address these gaps, the participation of Ethiopian students in global legal competitions will remain the exception rather than the norm. Addressing these challenges is a necessary first step toward unlocking the full potential of moot court programs across Ethiopian universities.

CHAPTER FOUR

BENEFITS OF MOOT COURT PARTICIPATION

Introduction

While numerous challenges hinder the participation of Ethiopian undergraduate law students in international moot court competitions, those who do engage report transformative academic and professional outcomes. This section explores the range of benefits associated with moot court involvement, drawing on students' testimonies to highlight how these experiences contribute to their legal training, personal development, and career aspirations. The responses gathered demonstrate that moot courts are not only competitive platforms but also essential tools for building core legal competencies and opening doors to international opportunities.

4.1. Skill Development

- **Legal Research:** Legal research is one of the most universally recognized skills gained through moot court. Twelve out of fourteen respondents agreed or strongly agreed that this skill was enhanced. Some respondents also identified it as the most beneficial skill and expressed interest in learning how participants prepared and conducted research.
- **Legal Writing:** Similarly, legal writing is highly valued. Twelve out of fourteen respondents agreed or strongly agreed that their writing skills improved. Students expressed interest in understanding how legal memoranda were drafted.

- **Public Speaking and Oral Advocacy:** Public speaking is identified as a crucial skill by eleven out of fourteen respondents. Many respondents also emphasized oral advocacy or legal speaking as the most beneficial skill gained. One respondent noted that moot court participation helped develop speaking skills, which are vital for formal litigation. Students also expressed interest in learning how oral arguments are delivered and what it takes to become an effective oralist.
- **Teamwork:** Eleven out of fourteen respondents agreed or strongly agreed that teamwork was a valuable skill they gained. Team collaboration was also frequently mentioned in other parts of the questionnaire.
- **Time Management:** Ten out of fourteen respondents reported improved time management skills, reflecting the demanding preparation schedule required for moot court.
- **Knowledge of International Arbitration:** For those who participated in the Vis Moot, gaining knowledge of international arbitration was a notable benefit. Ten out of fourteen respondents identified this as a valuable skill, which corresponds with the specialized nature of the competition.

Beyond these specific areas, respondents also mentioned growth in critical thinking, adaptability, legal analysis, and overall legal knowledge, as well as enhanced public speaking confidence.

4.2. Career Benefits and Networking

Moot court participation, particularly in international competitions, is perceived as offering clear career advantages.

- **Tangible Career Benefits:** In response to the question regarding whether Vis Moot participation leads to internships, scholarships, and networking opportunities, nine out of eleven respondents answered affirmatively. One respondent agreed to some extent.
- **Networking and Professional Development:** Ten out of fourteen respondents acknowledged networking and professional development as important benefits. Students expressed interest in learning about opportunities for networking and exposure. One respondent emphasized that the Vis Moot connects participants with students, professionals, and top arbitrators from around the world. Another added that the experience builds global connections.
- **Exposure to the Legal Community:** Students described the competition as a gateway to the broader international legal community. Participants gain insights into diverse legal cultures, advocacy styles, and a new legal environment. Competing with international peers was seen as a particularly valuable experience.
- **Holistic Development:** Students emphasized that moot court allows them to experience what it means to act as a legal representative. This contributes to a more complete and practical understanding of their future profession.

The findings confirm that moot court participation provides multifaceted value to law students. From sharpening legal research, writing, and advocacy skills to enhancing teamwork, time management, and global legal awareness, the experience bridges the gap between theoretical study and practical application. Moreover, students widely recognize the career and networking advantages, as well as the contribution moot courts make toward a richer and more practice-oriented legal education. These insights affirm that increased access to and engagement in international moot competitions can play a critical role in strengthening legal education in Ethiopia.

4.3. Enhancement of Legal Education

- **Academic Enrichment:** Eighteen out of nineteen respondents affirmed that moot court participation improves legal education. This overwhelming agreement highlights the integral role of mooting in legal training.
- **Practical Application of Law:** One respondent stated that learning the law is not enough without practical engagement. Moot court provides the opportunity to apply legal knowledge in simulated real-world scenarios, which is often missing from traditional coursework.



CHAPTER FIVE

CONCLUSION AND RECOMMENDATIONS

CONCLUSION

This study set out to explore the extent of exposure Ethiopian undergraduate law students have to international moot court competitions, identify the barriers limiting such exposure, and propose viable recommendations to improve their participation.

First, the data reveals a generally low but growing level of awareness and exposure to international moot court competitions among Ethiopian law students. While most students had heard of international moots in name, few had detailed knowledge of how they function or how to get involved. Despite this, there is a significant interest in participating, with many students recognizing the academic, professional, and personal value of such opportunities.

Second, multiple barriers hinder participation. The most prominent include financial constraints, insufficient information dissemination, lack of faculty mentorship and institutional support, and limited access to legal databases and training. Logistical issues such as visa acquisition, travel planning, and academic inflexibility also contribute to the challenges faced by prospective participants.

Finally, the findings emphasize that while Ethiopian law students have the motivation and capacity to compete internationally, structural and systemic obstacles prevent them from doing so. To bridge this gap, concrete institutional, pedagogical, and financial reforms are required.

RECOMMENDATIONS

To enhance the exposure of undergraduate law students in Ethiopia to international moot court competitions, it is essential to improve information dissemination and student awareness. Universities and legal institutions should launch targeted awareness campaigns that go beyond mere announcements. These should include detailed presentations on the nature, structure, and benefits of competitions such as the Vis Moot. Establishing dedicated information portals or sections within university websites will ensure that students have continuous access to updated competition details, timelines, and resources. Moreover, engaging alumni who have previously participated in international moots to share their experiences can offer relatable and motivating insights. Introducing moot courts and their international dimensions early in the academic journey, especially in the junior years, would also allow students sufficient time to prepare and develop interest.

To address the barriers hindering participation, universities must establish robust institutional support systems. This includes creating dedicated moot court programs or units with allocated staff and resources to coordinate efforts, provide mentorship, and guide students through the competition process. Faculty mentorship should be a core component, with trained coaches supporting students in legal research, oral advocacy, and memorial writing. Access to international legal databases such as Westlaw or Kluwer Arbitration should be prioritized through subscriptions or partnerships, ensuring that students are equipped with the tools necessary for competitive preparation. Universities must also facilitate the administrative aspects of participation, including visa processes and travel logistics.

Importantly, moot court participation should be recognized academically, either through credit or other formal incentives, acknowledging the rigor and value of these competitions.

Finally, to enhance and sustain meaningful engagement, stakeholders must develop strategic interventions aimed at overcoming the underlying challenges. Structured training modules covering advanced research, legal writing, oral advocacy, and arbitration law should be institutionalized. Regular pre-moots and practice rounds, both internally and in collaboration with other universities, should be held to offer students practical experience. Addressing financial constraints is equally critical. Partnerships with law firms, NGOs, and alumni networks should be pursued to provide direct sponsorship and small grants. University budgets should include dedicated funding for moot activities, while alternative strategies such as crowdfunding and seeking governmental or international support should also be explored. Cultivating a strong culture of mooting within law schools, through celebrating success stories, integrating mooting into legal curricula, and encouraging inter-university cooperation, will create a sustainable and empowering environment for Ethiopian law students to thrive on the global stage.



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